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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Rights cases flip under Trump

Education Dept. now scrutinizes measures aimed at fixing inequities

BY LAURA MECKLER

The Trump administration has upended civil rights enforcement at K-12 schools and colleges, prioritizing cases that allege transgender students and students of color are getting unfair advantages, while severe staff cuts have left thousands of other allegations unresolved.

The Education Department's Office for Civil Rights is so short-staffed that some attorneys have as many as 300 cases, making it impossible to devote attention to most of them, current and former employees said. Fewer cases are being closed, and 90 percent of those resolved were dismissed, typically without an investigation, up from 80 percent last year, according to data obtained by The Washington Post.

The office has a backlog of about 25,000 unresolved cases, up from about 20,000 when President Donald Trump took office, department officials said.

At the same time, under Trump, the civil rights office has announced investigations of at least 99 schools, often based on news coverage or complaints from conservative groups. As of early August, the administration had launched 27 directed investigations — probes that are opened without an outside complaint — court filings show.

These changes define the new tone and mission in the civil rights office, which is aggressively pursuing Trump's agenda. In choosing its targets, the administration is not just picking different priorities than its predecessors; it's flipping the interpretation of civil

SEE CIVIL RIGHTS ON A7

In Ukraine talks, little movement toward deal



TOM BRENNER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

President Donald Trump with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky and other European leaders at the White House.

Ukrainians feel war's staggering cost in children's lives

BY SERHII KOROLCHUK, ANASTACIA GALOUCHKA, SIOBHÁN O'GRADY AND OKSANA PARAFENIUK

Russia continues to relentlessly bombard Ukraine each day, killing and wounding civilians.

July was the deadliest month in Ukraine since the full-scale invasion began in 2022, with 286 people killed and 1,388 wounded, according to the United Nations. The number of civilians killed and wounded in Ukraine in the first seven months of the year increased by 48 percent compared with the same period the year before.

On Friday, President Donald Trump hosted Russian President Vladimir Putin in Alaska for di-



OKSANA PARAFENIUK/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Olena and Ihor Martyniuk lost three of their five children — Roman, 17, Tamara, 12, and Stanislav, 8 — in a missile attack.

rect talks, but the summit yielded no breakthrough or any sign that the attacks on Ukraine will end. Trump dropped his insistence on a ceasefire and Putin demanded territorial concessions that are unacceptable to Ukraine, according to officials familiar with the talks who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive diplomacy.

Ukraine has long agreed to a 30-day ceasefire to set the stage for negotiations to end the war. Russia has refused. Instead, it has ramped up attacks on heavily populated areas, according to independent military analysts and a Washington Post analysis of data from Ukraine's armed forces. Russia says it targets mili-

SEE CHILDREN ON A12

AI creators finding gold in flood of fake videos

BY DREW HARWELL

Luis Talavera, a 31-year-old loan officer in eastern Idaho, first went viral in June with an AI-generated video on TikTok in which a fake but lifelike old man talked about soiling himself. Within two weeks, he had used AI to pump out 91 more, mostly showing fake street interviews and jokes about fat people to an audience that has surged past 180,000 followers, some of whom comment to ask if the scenes are real.

The low-effort, high-volume nature of AI videos has earned them the nickname "AI slop," and Talavera knows his videos aren't high art. But they earn him about \$5,000 a month through TikTok's creator program, he said, so every night and weekend he spends hours churning them out. "I've been on my couch holding my 3-month-old daughter, saying, 'Hey, ChatGPT, we're gonna create this script,'" he said.

Nothing has transformed or polluted the creative landscape in the past few years quite like AI video, whose tools turn text

SEE AI VIDEOS ON A17

Democrats are returning to Texas, clearing way for GOP to draw new map

BY PATRICK MARLEY, YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ AND MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

Texas Republicans moved closer Monday to enacting a new congressional map designed to boost their chances in the mid-term elections as Democrats ended a two-week boycott aimed at stalling the plan.

Soon after the Democrats re-

turned, Republicans modified a proposed map that was already friendly to the GOP to make it even more favorable to their party.

With the Democrats back, Republicans, at the behest of President Donald Trump, plan to pass the new map by the end of the month.

In Washington, Republicans hold a 219-212 U.S. House majority with four vacancies, and a

broad, national fight over redrawing districts could determine which party wins control next year.

The political fight in Texas has grown personal. Soon after Democratic lawmakers returned from their walkout, Republicans who control the state House told them on the floor of the chamber that they would not be permitted to leave without a police escort to

ensure they would not flee the state again. Democrats were furious, with one lawmaker insisting she would instead spend the night in the statehouse to protest what she saw as an insult.

Republican leaders also announced a shift in the map as they began business Monday. This month, Republicans put forward a map that would give them an electoral advantage in up to five

more seats in Texas, including the district of Rep. Al Green (D). The new version released Monday would push Green's district even further to the right. A full analysis of the new map was not immediately available late Monday.

The Democrats who fled the

SEE TEXAS ON A4

California: Democrats are working on their own redistricting effort. **A3**



JAMES ROH/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Kevin Perry captures a dust event on his phone on the exposed lakebed of the Great Salt Lake in July.

A drying Great Salt Lake holds a new hazard

Frequent dust events carry a carcinogenic threat

BY RUBY MELLEN AND JAMES ROH

GREAT SALT LAKE, UTAH — Kevin Perry was standing on the parched lakebed when the wind started to pick up.

He squinted across a cracked, gray expanse of earth, submerged 16 feet underwater just five decades ago, and saw a wall of dust headed straight for him.

The sand-like specks — probably laced with arsenic and other carcinogenic metals — stung his bare arms and legs as the gusts intensified. After several minutes of deafening squalls and blinding grime, the wind stilled, but the cloud kept barreling toward the

shore. "And it's rolling into all those neighborhoods," said Perry, gazing at dozens of homes that have cropped up near what was once the shore of one of the West's most famous landmarks.

"The question is, how much of it?"

Dozens of dust events like this, carrying harmful heavy metals and chemicals, probably happen each year across the 120-square-mile playa once covered by the Great Salt Lake, before water diversions, drought and heat caused it to shrink to record lows. But there are no comprehensive state or federal records of them —

SEE LAKE ON A22

IN THE NEWS

National Guard As a fourth GOP governor announced plans for a troop deployment in the capital, D.C. officials and residents questioned the need for the influx. **B13**

Epstein case files The Justice Department has agreed to show Congress documents from its investigation of the sex offender. **A5**

THE NATION **Trans rights**, once a winning issue for North Carolina's Roy Cooper, are now seen as a liability as he runs for Senate. **A3** **A trans runner** sued the NCAA and her college over a policy change. **A6**

THE WORLD **Bolivia's socialist** movement was defeated in the race for president, early results showed. **A10** **Three Afghans** eligible to seek asylum in Canada are languishing in U.S. custody. **A11**

THE ECONOMY **Even tech-savvy** seniors can feel overwhelmed by AI, so classes are helping them grasp the risks and possibilities. **A16** **Modern medicine's** dependence on horseshoe crab blood is upending a globe-spanning ecosystem, conservationists warn. **A18**

STYLE **Newsmax** will pay \$67 million to settle a defamation lawsuit from Dominion Voting Systems against the right-wing news channel. **B1** **MSNBC** will formally change its name later this year to MS Now as part of a corporate transformation. **B1**

SPORTS **In the WNBA**, the looming labor battle gives young stars a crash course in the business of basketball. **B7**

THE REGION **Students in Fairfax** County had a lot on their minds that they wanted to share on the first day of school. **B13**

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